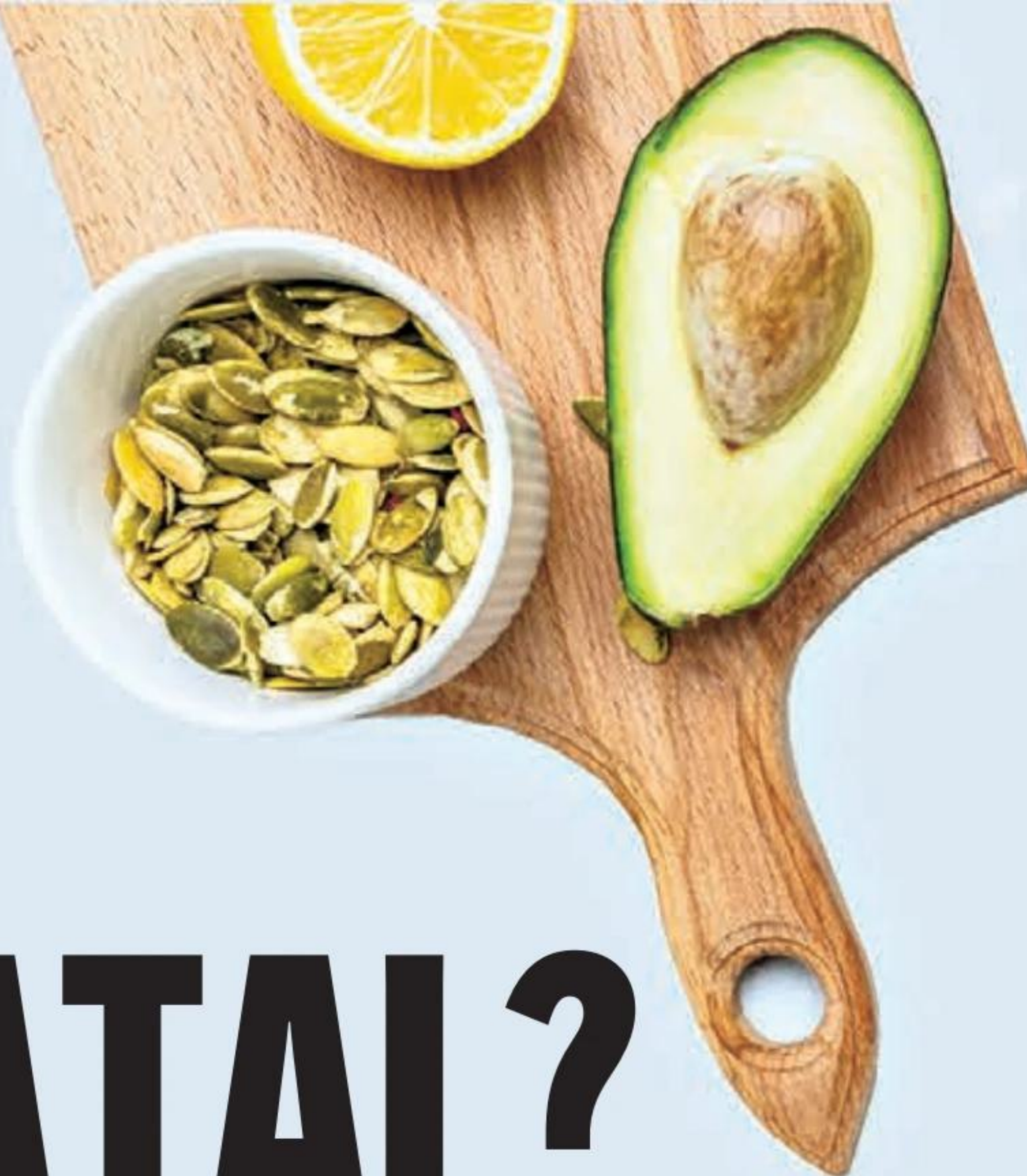




FOOD FOR THOUGHT

Ryan Fernando



FAD OR FATAL?

Ryan Fernando explores how **trending diets** might be hurting athlete performance.



In today's world, your diet is as much a flex as your gym stats. Scroll through social media and you'll find everyone, from celebrities to recreational athletes, swearing by keto, intermittent fasting, or juice cleanses. But as a sports nutritionist, I have to ask a more serious question:

Are these trends really improving your performance, or silently sabotaging it?

Let's break them down through an athletic lens.

Intermittent Fasting — Boosting Discipline or Draining Endurance?

Intermittent fasting (IF) is gaining popularity. But when your eating window becomes too narrow, your muscles can't recover properly, and your energy may drop before the start of your training. A 2024 study by the American Heart Association found that individuals on an eight-hour eating window had a 91 per cent higher risk of cardiovascular death compared to those with more balanced meal timings. This is particularly concerning for athletes, given that the demands placed on their cardiovascular and muscular systems are quite a bit higher than for the average person.

Athlete Tip: If you're practising IF while training hard, ensure meals are timed around workouts to optimise your energy and recovery.

Ryan's Rule: Fasting is a discipline, not a punishment. If you're feeling weak, foggy, or underperforming, it's time to adjust.

Keto — High Fat, Low Carb... and Lower Performance?

The ketogenic diet includes plenty of paneer, eggs,

and butter, which can appeal to Indian food lovers. However, for athletes, the lack of carbohydrates can reduce muscle glycogen stores — essential for sustained energy, high-intensity efforts, and proper recovery.

A study in *Frontiers in Nutrition* noted that while keto may support blood sugar regulation in the short term, it can raise LDL cholesterol and impair endurance performance over time.

Athlete Tip: Short-term keto may help with fat adaptation, but for high-performance training, carbohydrates are key to fuelling and recovery.

Ryan's Rule: If your sport requires stamina, speed, or explosive power, a keto diet may hold you back more than it can help.

Juice Cleanses — Detoxing or Depleting?

Juice cleanses are often marketed as a way to reset the body. But in practice, they spike blood sugar, lack protein, and can trigger muscle loss — the very opposite of what athletes need.

One glass of cold-pressed orange